making was seen to have been concentrated within a small circle around Abhishek, and the corporate-style advisors IPAC.

## DECIMATION TIME

Yet, no one imagined such a dramatic unravelling for a party that had won 42 per cent of the popular vote in April, even while facing the ignominy of being reduced from its commanding heights to less than one-third of the new House by the Bharatiya Janata Party. As often happens with the latter, its rivals dwindle post-election too. Mamata's camp now owns below 7 per cent of the legislative real estate.

Does she still own Brand TMC? It's a curiously open game. Mamata built that brand over 28 years around her irrepressible personality: a czarina-like authority, with chutzpah to spare. Now, a leader from an entirely different political tradition has bitten off its biggest legislative chunk. It may move towards a legal battle over the TMC's 'twin grass flowers' symbol. But, for now, the rebel MLAs have stopped short of demanding Mamata's removal as TMC chairperson and organisational head. In their formal submissions, they explicitly state they still recognise her as the party's chief and "chief advisor". The civil war seems aimed more at the nephew. "People were angry before. But that day united everyone," says a rebel MLA on the staged applause drama.

Politics often comes full circle in unexpected ways. In a polity where cross-border migration is a hot-button topic, a personage who has doubled his number of crossings is now the centre of attention. First rising to prominence through the Students' Federation of India, the CPI(M) nursery, he was once considered close to former CM Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee. His career there had run into quicksand amid allegations of financial irregularities and a 'posh' lifestyle unbecoming of a communist.

But Ritabrata may have finally achieved what many veterans of the Left could not manage after 2011. Mamata ended the Left's 34-year reign. Now, one of its stray comets crashes her party. As for Abhishek, days after a mob attack, he finds himself fending off arrest. ■



IANS

**IN A TIGHT CORNER** Former West Bengal CM and Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee at a protest rally in central Kolkata, Jun. 2

*By* **Rahul Noronha**

**AS THE LAST CENTURY GROANED** forward, those with a rosy view of the past have sought to hold on to a kind of sepia-tinted idea of princely generosity. Look no further than the Bhopal *rubaats*, or guesthouses for Haj pilgrims in Mecca and Medina, constructed during the reign of Bhopal's begums Shah Jahan and her daughter Sultan Jehan, together dating from 1838-1930. At least since 1920, these structures have offered refuge to the city's devout who made what's a once-in-a-lifetime trip to the holy lands—no doubt, for these travellers, they also stood as a comforting emotional bridge to what's seen as the 'Golden Era' of the Bhopal nawabs.

But today, with the messy ways of democracy, such ideas perish fast—what with a rising sense of community entitlement. Controversy has attended the *rubaats* for long, but it peaked recently after a Bhopal Congress MLA accused its custodians of mismanagement, to the extent that it left pilgrims bereft of a place to stay during the Haj. Caught in the centre of the row are Bhopal-based industrialist Sikander Hafiz Khan as well as Saba Sultan, the daughter of cricket icon M.A.K. Pataudi and Sharmila Tagore, often seen as the most reticent of the celebrity clan.

These properties are under the Aukaf-e-Shahi, a body that manages the network of religious properties and endowments created by Bhopal's erstwhile ruling family. Saba has been the Mutawalli, or custodian of the Aukaf-e-Shahi, since October 2011. Sikandar Hafiz Khan, a prime target of the accusers, has her power of attorney.

## TECHNICAL KNOCKOUT

What's the genesis of all this? Over the decades, expansion projects in Mecca and Medina led to the original guesthouses being dismantled. The compensation money was used to buy new properties so the tradition of free accommodation for Hajis could